

**THE CO-ED SLOWPITCH SOFTBALL
DEFENSIVE LINEUP LEGALITY, COMPOSITION,
ELIGIBILITY, AND CONTINUING COMPLIANCE CODE**

(the “Lineup Code”)

EFFECTIVE JULY 2026

PREAMBLE AND RECITALS

WHEREAS, the orderly administration of co-ed slowpitch softball requires that each defensive half-inning be contested by a properly constituted, positionally complete, gender-compliant, and duly authorized fielding complement;

WHEREAS, the unauthorized occupation, abandonment, duplication, or improvised reclassification of any defensive position threatens the integrity of the lineup as a whole and shall not be excused merely because the ball has already been put into play;

WHEREAS, compliance is not a matter of substantial approximation, customary practice, good intentions, optimistic head-counting, or the manager’s sincere belief that the arrangement “is probably close enough”;

WHEREAS, the requirements stated herein are cumulative, inning specific, and of continuing force, such that compliance during one inning creates no presumption whatsoever of compliance during any subsequent inning; and

WHEREAS, failure to observe these requirements may subject the offending lineup, its preparers, and the Club on whose behalf it is tendered to immediate corrective action and such further consequences as the competent authority may deem necessary, appropriate, exemplary, or uncomfortably memorable;

NOW, THEREFORE, the following provisions are hereby declared to govern the preparation, review, issuance, and continued use of every seven-inning defensive lineup.

**ARTICLE I
DEFINITIONS AND RULES OF CONSTRUCTION**

§ 1.01. Defined Terms.

For purposes of this Lineup Code, the following terms shall have the meanings set forth below, whether used in the singular or plural:

- (a) **“Active Position”** means a defensive position that is required to be occupied under the applicable Fielding Complement.
- (b) **“Available Player”** means a rostered player affirmatively designated as available for the game in question. Mere presence in the vicinity of the field shall not, standing alone, constitute availability.
- (c) **“Defensive Inning”** means each of the seven separately regulated innings for which a defensive assignment is issued.
- (d) **“Fielding Complement”** means the legally permissible group of eight, nine, or ten players assigned to the defense in a Defensive Inning.
- (e) **“Infield”** means P, C, 1B, 2B, 3B, and SS. For the avoidance of doubt, and notwithstanding any contrary dugout folklore, both P and C are Infield positions.
- (f) **“Outfield”** means LF, LC, RC, and RF.
- (g) **“Position Preference”** means a position for which a player has been affirmatively declared eligible. Position Preferences are unranked and equally preferred, but they are not optional suggestions.
- (h) **“Woman Player”** means an Available Player identified as a woman in the roster data governing the applicable game.

§ 1.02. Strict and Cumulative Construction.

Every “shall,” “must,” and “may not” appearing herein is mandatory. Each requirement applies in addition to, and not in substitution for, every other requirement. Satisfaction of the numerical requirement shall not cure a geographic defect; satisfaction of the geographic requirement shall not cure an eligibility defect; and no aggregation of partial compliance shall be recognized as the legal equivalent of complete compliance.

ARTICLE II AUTHORIZED FIELDING COMPLEMENTS

§ 2.01. Ten-Player Complement.

A ten-player Fielding Complement shall occupy all of the following positions: P, C, 1B, 2B, 3B, SS, LF, LC, RC, and RF. It shall include no fewer than four Woman Players, of whom no fewer than one shall be stationed in the Infield and no fewer than one shall be stationed in the Outfield.

§ 2.02. Nine-Player Complement.

If a lawful ten-player Fielding Complement cannot be constituted because fewer than ten players are available or because fewer than four Woman Players are available, a nine-player Fielding Complement may be constituted only if:

- (i) at least nine players are available;
- (ii) at least three of those players are Woman Players;
- (iii) RF is left wholly and conspicuously unoccupied;

- (iv) each of P, C, 1B, 2B, 3B, SS, LF, LC, and RC is occupied exactly once; and
- (v) at least one Woman Player occupies the Infield and at least one Woman Player occupies the Outfield.

No tenth player may be introduced as a rover, auxiliary fielder, informal short-fielder, or person who is “just standing over there.”

§ 2.03. Eight-Player Complement.

An eight-player Fielding Complement may be constituted only if exactly eight players, including at least three Woman Players, are available for assignment. In such event, C and RF shall remain unoccupied; each of P, 1B, 2B, 3B, SS, LF, LC, and RC shall be occupied exactly once; at least one Woman Player shall occupy the Infield; and at least one Woman Player shall occupy the Outfield.

§ 2.04. Mandatory Maximum Lawful Complement.

The largest lawful Fielding Complement supported by the available roster shall govern. A smaller complement may not be selected merely for convenience, aesthetic symmetry, strategic experimentation, avoidance of difficult decisions, or relief from the administrative burden of counting.

§ 2.05. Absolute Minimum.

Fewer than eight Available Players, or fewer than three available Woman Players, is legally insufficient to constitute any Fielding Complement recognized under this Lineup Code. No amount of enthusiasm, positional versatility, arithmetic creativity, or informal consensus shall cure such deficiency.

ARTICLE III PER-INNING ASSIGNMENT REQUIREMENTS

§ 3.01. Exact Occupancy.

For each Defensive Inning, every Active Position shall be assigned to exactly one eligible Available Player. No Active Position may be vacant, shared, alternated within the same assignment, reserved for later determination, or filled by a player identified only as “TBD.”

§ 3.02. Single-Position Limitation.

No player may occupy, be credited with, or be assigned responsibility for more than one defensive position during the same Defensive Inning. Athletic range, confidence, prior experience, and an expressed willingness to “cover both” shall have no legal effect.

§ 3.03. Inactive Positions.

Every position rendered inactive by Article II shall remain empty for the entire applicable Defensive Inning. The omission of C or RF is a prescribed structural condition, not an invitation to rename, relocate, or disguise an additional fielder.

§ 3.04. Independent Inning Review.

The requirements of this Article shall be independently satisfied in each of the seven Defensive Innings. A player substitution, positional transfer, or return from sitting out shall trigger renewed compliance review. Legality does not vest permanently upon acceptance of the first-inning lineup.

ARTICLE IV POSITIONAL ELIGIBILITY

§ 4.01. Preference as Authorization.

Except as expressly provided in § 4.02, a player may be assigned only to a position contained in that player's recorded Position Preferences. Silence, blank data, assumed competence, necessity, and the manager's personal assessment that a player "can probably handle it" shall not constitute authorization.

§ 4.02. Limited RF-to-RC Operation of Law.

Solely when an eight- or nine-player Fielding Complement is in effect, a recorded preference for RF shall automatically confer eligibility for RC for that game. This narrowly drawn legal fiction exists because RF is inactive in both such complements.

§ 4.03. No Implied Expansion.

The rule in § 4.02 shall not be construed to:

- (a) confer RF eligibility from an RC preference;
- (b) confer eligibility for LC, LF, or any Infield position;
- (c) operate in a ten-player Fielding Complement; or
- (d) establish any broader doctrine of "close enough" positional equivalence.

ARTICLE V PRIORITY, ADMINISTRATION, AND RECORDS

§ 5.01. Supremacy of Legality.

The requirements of Articles II through IV are conditions precedent to a valid lineup. Goals concerning equal playing time, continuous assignments, player satisfaction, or limiting the number of distinct positions are subordinate and shall not excuse, offset, or retroactively sanitize an unlawful assignment.

§ 5.02. Roster and Availability Record.

Before a lineup is generated, the responsible manager shall maintain an accurate record of player names, gender designations, Position Preferences, and game-specific availability. Any lineup derived from materially inaccurate input shall be treated as suspect from inception and shall remain subject to immediate review, reformation, and replacement.

§ 5.03. Burden of Verification.

The person presenting or using a lineup bears the continuing burden of verifying its compliance. Reliance upon software, a prior lineup, a spreadsheet, an unreviewed text message, or the confident assurances of another person shall not transfer, diminish, or extinguish that burden.

§ 5.04. No Waiver by Inattention.

The failure of any player, manager, spectator, opposing participant, or other interested person to identify a defect immediately shall not constitute approval, ratification, waiver, estoppel, acquiescence, or evidence that the defect was too minor to matter.

ARTICLE VI NONCOMPLIANCE AND CONSEQUENCES

§ 6.01. Material Breach.

Any violation of Articles II, III, or IV shall constitute a material lineup defect. A defective assignment is noncompliant *ab initio* and shall not be rehabilitated by competent play, favorable results, lack of objection, or the subsequent discovery that no batted ball reached the improperly arranged portion of the field.

§ 6.02. Corrective Authority.

Upon actual or suspected noncompliance, the competent authority may require immediate cessation, compulsory reassignment, submission of a replacement lineup, removal of an ineligible assignment, formal explanation, renewed certification, or any combination thereof. Nothing herein shall require that advance notice or a leisurely opportunity to cure be afforded before such measures are imposed.

§ 6.03. Reservation of Consequences.

The remedies stated in § 6.02 are not exclusive. A violation may expose the lineup and the Club to disallowance, nullification, forfeiture, adverse determination, reputational censure, and such additional sanctions, consequences, or solemn administrative disappointment as may lie within the jurisdiction of the governing authority. The absence of a separately enumerated penalty shall not be interpreted as permission.

ARTICLE VII FINAL PROVISIONS

§ 7.01. Severability.

If any provision of this Lineup Code is determined to be invalid or unenforceable, the remaining provisions shall continue in full force, and the invalid provision shall be construed as narrowly as necessary to preserve the maximum lawful degree of lineup regulation.

§ 7.02. Amendment.

No amendment, exception, side agreement, dugout proclamation, or purported waiver shall be effective unless incorporated into the governing lineup rules and, where applicable, the optimization system itself. Oral modifications made while the teams are taking the field are strongly disfavored.

§ 7.03. Headings.

Article and section headings are supplied for organizational convenience and shall not be invoked to evade the plain, stern, and unmistakable meaning of the operative text.

§ 7.04. Effective Scope.

This Lineup Code applies to one game at a time and to all seven Defensive Innings of each such game. It shall take effect upon preparation of the lineup and remain in force until the final defensive assignment has concluded or all compliance questions have been resolved, whichever occurs later.

CERTIFICATION OF LINEUP COMPLIANCE

By presenting a defensive lineup for use, the undersigned certifies, under the full weight of managerial responsibility, that the lineup has been reviewed for exact positional occupancy, player eligibility, minimum participation by Woman Players, required Infield and Outfield placement, and all other matters set forth herein.

Responsible Manager

Date and Time of Certification